

Russian cities in early 1844, Clara was the star, not her husband.

Mental suffering

In fall 1844, Schumann moved with his family from Leipzig to Dresden, abandoning his editorial role on the New Journal for Music. It was in Dresden that he began to suffer from aural hallucinations, as well as anxieties, phobias, and depression. This did not stop him producing a steady stream of new compositions, including the Manfred Overture, written in 1848, which was destined to become his most frequently performed orchestral piece. He placed great hopes in his opera Genoveva, but this was poorly received when premiered in 1850.

That year, Schumann took up a post as musical director in Düsseldorf on the Rhine. The new location provoked a burst of creativity, both his “Rhenish” Symphony and his Cello Concerto, written in the first few months after arrival. However, Schumann’s mental condition soon began to deteriorate alarmingly. He was plagued by a cacophony of musical notes and voices in his ears and saw visions of angels and devils. His duties as musical director included conducting an orchestra and choir. By 1853, his eccentric performances on the podium had caused a storm of local criticism and he was forced to resign.